

Silly fonts—or fonts for kids, not to imply that all kids are silly—include Comic Sans, various hand-writing fonts, Chiller, and such. The tremendous popularity of Comic Sans stems from the fact that it does lighten up the mood; but no-one wants their mood being constantly lightened up. Perhaps, then, you could use it in the opening slide. Perhaps.

Avoid boring fonts such as Times New Roman and Microsoft Serif.

Tip

Think about the message or core information you want to get across. Then think about the character that each font, colour, etc. lends. You'll get these right if you're able to mentally form a wholesome picture of what your slide looks like with those fonts and colours.

The best way to gauge whether you've used the right fonts is to ask friends before the presentation—if you have that luxury, that is.

Readability

There should be enough colour contrast between the text and the background: if the text must be yellow, don't use a white background. If the background is blue, skip black and green as text colour choices. Also remember that what these look like on your monitor will not be the same as will be rendered on-screen by a projector, so test the slide on the projector first. In any case, if you want to play it safe, white on blue is good enough in most cases.

As a general rule, never keep any text smaller than 18 pt.

Use plenty of white space—that is, don't cramp the text too much.

Just as you'd never use all caps in an e-mail, never do so in a slide. In e-mail or IM, it's the equivalent of shouting; with slides, it's either that or it's about begging for attention.

Now here's a debatable point, but it must be pointed out that